

CM1400 UNIT 1 - GRAMMAR CHEAT SHEET

Plain-English version: identify what a word/sentence is doing, not just what the label is called.

1. Parts of Speech

Noun = person, place, thing, or idea *Example: server, Brenda, website, security*

Pronoun = replaces a noun *Example: it, she, they, this*

Verb = action or state of being *Example: runs, failed, is, seems*

Adjective = describes a noun *Example: slow server; secure wallet*

Adverb = describes a verb, adjective, or adverb *Example: runs slowly; very secure*

Preposition = shows position, time, or relationship *Example: in, on, under, after, with*

Conjunction = joins words or ideas *Example: and, but, because, although*

Interjection = short emotional expression *Example: wow, oh, damn*

2. Sentence Anatomy

Subject = who/what the sentence is about *Example: The API failed.*

Predicate = what the subject does/is *Example: The API failed.*

Direct object = receives the action *Example: The script reads the file.*

Indirect object = receives the direct object *Example: She sent the client a report.*

Phrase = group of words without a complete subject + verb *Example: after the update*

Clause = group of words with a subject + verb *Example: because the token expired*

Independent clause = can stand alone as a sentence *Example: The server crashed.*

Dependent clause = cannot stand alone *Example: because the server crashed*

3. Sentence Types

Simple = one independent clause *Example: The API failed.*

Compound = two independent clauses joined correctly *Example: The API failed, so I retried it.*

Complex = independent clause + dependent clause *Example: The API failed because the token expired.*

Compound-complex = 2+ independent clauses + at least 1 dependent clause *Example: The API failed because the token expired, so I refreshed it and tried again.*

4. Common Sentence Problems

Fragment = incomplete thought *Example: Because the token expired. -> Add the missing main clause.*

Run-on / fused sentence = two complete sentences jammed together *Example: It failed I retried it. -> Add punctuation/conjunction.*

Comma splice = two complete sentences joined only by a comma *Example: It failed, I retried it. -> Period, semicolon, or conjunction.*

Dangling modifier = intro phrase points to the wrong subject *Example: After testing the app, the bug was found. -> After testing the app, I found the bug.*

Sentence shift = unnecessary change in tense/person/number *Example: You install the app, then we restart it. -> Keep the viewpoint consistent.*

Pronoun problem = unclear what a pronoun refers to *Example: When the app hit the server, it failed. -> Say what failed.*

Subject-verb agreement = subject and verb must match *Example: The files are / The file is*

5. Clear Technical Style

Active voice = subject performs the action *Example: The developer fixed the bug.*

Passive voice = subject receives the action *Example: The bug was fixed by the developer.*

Parallel structure = items in a list use the same grammatical form *Example: testing, debugging, and documenting*

Concise writing = remove repetition and filler *Example: The API request failed with a 401 because the token expired.*

Audience = include enough context for the intended reader *Example: Dev: 401, expired token. Non-dev: explain what that means.*

6. Punctuation Quick Hits

Comma = separates items, intro elements, or clauses with a conjunction *Example: After testing, I restarted it.*

Semicolon = joins closely related independent clauses *Example: The token expired; the request failed.*

Colon = introduces a list/explanation after a complete clause *Example: The system needs three things: power, network access, and storage.*

Apostrophe = possession or contraction *Example: the server's log; it's = it is*

Hyphen = joins certain compound modifiers *Example: user-friendly interface*

7. Paragraph Checklist

Topic sentence = states the paragraph's main point

Unity = every sentence supports that one point

Coherence = ideas connect in a logical order

Development = include enough detail/examples to explain the point

Closing/transition = wrap up or move naturally to the next idea

Fast test: Who/what? -> SUBJECT | What happened? -> VERB/PREDICATE | Can it stand alone? -> INDEPENDENT CLAUSE